



Shining through: Jammu & Kashmir's Auqib Nabi, the breakout pacer of the 2024–25 Ranji Trophy, claimed 44 wickets at a stunning average of 13.93 to script the team's first quarterfinal finish. EMMANUAL YOGINI

Another winter, another reckoning

As the **Ranji Trophy** returns, India's selectors look beneath the surface — for fast bowlers who can last, and a batting order that can hold.

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Over the last few years, Indian cricket has wrestled with a familiar debate: do Indian Premier League performances carry more weight than those in domestic cricket? While several players have earned national call-ups on the back of IPL success, the Ranji Trophy remains the true testing ground for those aspiring to play the longest format.

Since last season, the Board of

Control for Cricket in India's (BCCI) directive that all players, unless on national duty, must feature in domestic tournaments has brought a sense of order. The sight of established internationals turning out in Ranji group matches has created a rare level playing field. As a former national selector once said, every domestic season presents a different challenge, and the selection priorities shift with the needs of the national team.

So, what should be the focus this time?

Former India pacer Subroto Banerjee, who was until recently a

member of the national selection committee, believes the emphasis this season should be on identifying and building a pool of quality fast bowlers, and a few fast-bowling all-rounders, ready to step up when required.

Over the last few months, workload management has dominated conversations around India's pace attack. Jasprit Bumrah played only three of five Tests in England, while Mohammed Siraj bowled an extraordinary 185.3 overs — 1,113 deliveries — to finish as the series' leading wicket-taker with 23 wickets. That effort also reignited an